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Touring The Training Camps

By GAYLE TALBOT

PHOENIX, Ariz., April 7. (AP)—Out here in the cattle and cotton country they hold firmly to the belief that Syd Cohen, who has been pitching and managing ball clubs around these parts for a couple of decades, is the most colorful character the game has produced since Rube Waddell, another lefthander.

They are proud of the fact that Syd was the last pitcher in the American league to throw a homerun ball to Babe Ruth. That was in 1934, during Syd's brief association with Washington. His older brother, Andy, played some infield for John McGraw's Giants in the twenties and currently is a highly successful manager at Denver.

They tell a hundred stories of Syd and his fierce desire to win ball games in the Arizona-Texas league. Our personal favorite is the one related with great relish by Buck Elliott, present manager of the Phoenix Senators. He says it gives an idea of how stubborn Syd can be.

Very Stubborn

Seems that one night back in '49, Syd's El Paso team and Elliott's Bisbee-Douglas entry hooked up in a night game at Douglas. Syd was, of course, on the hill for the visitors, and there was a rare threat of rain in the air. From here on it's Elliott's yarn:

"Well, Syd's team jumped on us right from the start and ran up a 9-0 lead after a couple of innings (Buck recalls). Syd was pitching so fast when we were at bat that he didn't even bother to wind-up.

"Finally it came the last of the fifth and you could feel the rain in the air. Syd needed only three more outs to make it an official game, and he was really pumping. We adopted all the bush league tactics you ever heard of, such as tying our shoes between pitches, but he got two of us out in spite of everything we could do.

"When our third batter didn't get into the box quickly enough, the umpire ordered Syd to pitch anyway. Syd threw two in a hurry and the ump called them automatic strikes. On the third pitch my batter jumped into the box and managed to get his bat on the ball and foul it off.

The Rain Came

"And right at that instant, so help me, the damndest rain storm Arizona ever had hit that ball park. A lightning bolt hit the transformer, or something, and every light in town went out, including those in the park. We all ran for the dressing room to keep from drowning. It was pitch dark.

"After about 30 minutes the downpour let up a little and I suddenly remembered that in the rush I had left the box containing our valuables on the bench. We don't have a regular lock box in the dressing room like big league teams. I groped my way out up to my ankles inwater, and when I stepped down into that dugout I went up to my knees.

"I found the box and was starting to wade back when I heard this slush-slush sound. I thought I was hearing things, because I knew nobody was out there, but I kept hearing it, and pretty soon I see this figure coming out of the gloom. It was Syd, and he passed within three feet without seeing me.

"He had been standing out there on that mound for 30 minutes, waiting to make that last pitch. I heard later he was so wet that the tobacco in his upper pocket had dissolved and run all over him.

"We nearly had it out at home plate the next night. Syd called me a lot of things you couldn't put in print and accused me of turning out the lights on him. He won't believe it was an act of providence yet."

National Loop Made Change In 24 Hours

BRADENTON, Fla.—Fred Fleig, assistant to National League President Warren C. Giles, really went into action within minutes after the Boston Braves. He was in charge of changing the schedule which puts Pittsburgh in the east and Milwaukee in the west.

When the baseball franchise shift was completed, Fleig talked to Branch Rickey of the Pirates, Bob Carpenter of the Phillies, Horace Stoneham of the Giants and Walter O'Malley of the Dodgers. That night he drove from St. Petersburg to Tampa to see Giles, Gabe Paul of the Reds, Jim Gallagher of the Cubs and Bill Walsingham of the Cardinals.

The next morning he phoned Buzzie Bavasi of the Dodgers and Jim Herron in Pittsburgh. At nine that morning he was on his way here to confer with General Manager John Quinn of the Braves regarding schedule changes.

At noon the Boston Braves became the Milwaukee Braves, on the schedule, and 28 Boston night games became 32 Milwaukee floodlight games.

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